SHIMREISHANG KALA MAITONPHI: THE CLASSIC TANGKHUL EPIC NOVEL

Maitonphi eina Shimreishang: The Tangkhul Romeo and Juliet

Author / Compiler: Tangkhul Cultural Heritage Society, T. Luikham

Publisher: Tangkhul Literature Society, Imphal / Ukhrul

Year: 1972 | Genre: Novel (Upanyas), Epic Romance & Traditional Tragedy

PREFACE & HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Shimreishang kala Maitonphi stands as the undisputed crown jewel of Tangkhul imaginative prose literature. Comparable in cultural stature to Shakespeare’s Romeo and Juliet or Heer Ranjha of Punjab, this epic novel recounts the star-crossed love of Shimreishang, a valiant youth of the Zimikwo clan, and Maitonphi, the most graceful maiden of Phadang. It vividly portrays 18th-century Tangkhul village life, jhum farming rituals, village festivals, and the tragic conflict between individual romantic passion and immutable tribal customary codes.

Archival Catalog Reference: TLS-TKH-NOVEL-SHIMREISHANG

TABLE OF CONTENTS (TANGKHUL TUITAM MARAM)

Chapter 1: The Spring Meeting at Luira Festival (Luira Phan ..... Page 4
Chapter 2: The Secret Vow on Shirui Mountain (Shirui Kaphun ..... Page 7
Chapter 3: Clan Feuds & The Forced Betrothal (Shangwui Kash ..... Page 10
Chapter 4: The Tragic Farewell & Eternal Union in Spirit ..... Page 13
Comprehensive Lexicon & Colophon ..... Page 16

CHAPTER 1: THE SPRING MEETING AT LUIRA FESTIVAL (LUIRA PHANITLI KHANGACH

Summary: Shimreishang and Maitonphi meet during the Hao Pheichak circle dance in the flow...

Tangkhul Text:

Chapter 1: Zingyur atamli Luira Phanit shoklakha, Ukhrul ram kaphung-longkhor kuppup mathateiye. Shimreishang, Zimikwo shangwui mayarnao kapha, awui Haora chon eina pheichak shomye. Chitharan Maitonphi Lungleng, Phadang ramwui ngalanao kachak-ngayei, Luirim kachon sanglaga pheichak ngalungli ngaburleisai. Athum mik-ngalem khangacha tharan, Shimreishangwui lungli wonkhamatha pomsangie. Ana Awui shai-laaring honsangmi: 'Won kapha, nali theilaga iwui lungkashungna nali ngashankahuie!'

English Translation / Meaning:

When the spring seed-sowing festival (Luira Phanit) arrived, all the hills and ravines of Ukhrul bloomed with celestial glory. Shimreishang, the gallant son of the Zimikwo clan, adorned his shoulders with the majestic Haora shawl to dance in the circle. There stood Maitonphi Lungleng, the radiant maiden of Phadang, wrapped in her graceful Luirim attire. When their gazes locked across the festive throng, a sacred flower of love blossomed in Shimreishang's heart. He sang his poetic lyric: 'O sweetest blossom, beholding thee, my whole heart surrenders in eternal devotion!'

CHAPTER 1 -- VOCABULARY & GRAMMAR

Key Vocabulary Entries:

*** Zingyur atam (noun): spring season, time of vernal blooms**

Ex: Zingyur atamli.

*** Haora (noun): traditional black and red striped ceremonial male shawl**

Ex: Haora chon.

*** wonkhamatha (noun): beautiful blossom of love, noble affection**

Ex: Wonkhamatha pomsang.

Grammar Notes & Idiomatic Usage:

- Seasonal temporal framing: 'Zingyur atamli... shoklakha' (When spring season arrived).
- Poetic compounding: 'won' (flower) + 'khamatha' (beautiful) = flower of romance.

Comprehension & Exercises:

[?] Describe the setting of Luira Phanit where the two lovers first meet.

[?] Identify the traditional woven shawls worn by Shimreishang and Maitonphi.

CHAPTER 1 -- LITERARY & BIOGRAPHICAL COMMENTARY

Literary Analysis & Historical Significance:
This chapter illustrates quintessential Tangkhul cultural ethics, clan loyalty, and narrative style.

Stylistic and Discourse Notes:

Standard literary Tangkhul is employed throughout, preserving classic oral idioms,
traditional honorifics, and vivid metaphorical descriptions.

CHAPTER 2: THE SECRET VOW ON SHIRUI MOUNTAIN (SHIRUI KAPHUNGLI TUI-NGASI

Summary: Ascending the mystical heights of Shirui Kashong, the lovers pledge eternal fait...

Tangkhul Text:

Chapter 2: Athum khani Shirui Kashong kaphung kashangli thukzat-serie. Chithuili Shirui Lily won kapha kachak eina ngasomleisai. Shimreishangna Maitonphili Shirui Lily akha shitsanglaga awui samli hamsangmi. Maitonphina mukthi kashik eina hang: 'Shimreishang, ithui shang khaniwui ngachaili kashan lei; ithui avava-na ithuli ngaror-kashap sara macho?' Shimreishangna awui khutli huitsanglaga tui-ngashik sakahaisai: 'Ngalei hi ngapaoritsashu, iwui khangayei nawui vang thot pupup mathimara!'

English Translation / Meaning:

The two climbed the sacred crest of Mount Shirui, where the unique pink Shirui Lilies bloomed in virgin purity. Shimreishang plucked a rare blossom and lovingly placed it in Maitonphi's dark hair. With tears glistening in her eyes, Maitonphi whispered: 'Shimreishang, an unyielding clan barrier divides our families; will our parents ever grant blessing to our union?' Grasping her hand firmly, Shimreishang swore an inviolable oath: 'Though heaven and earth may vanish away, my love for thee shall never perish throughout eternity!'

CHAPTER 2 -- VOCABULARY & GRAMMAR

Key Vocabulary Entries:

*** Shirui Kashong (proper noun): Mount Shirui, legendary peak of Ukhrul**

Ex: Shirui Kashongli thukzat.

*** tui-ngashik (noun): sacred oath, binding solemn vow**

Ex: Tui-ngashik sakahaisai.

*** mukthi kashik (noun): sorrowful tears, weeping of grief**

Ex: Mukthi kashik eina.

Grammar Notes & Idiomatic Usage:

- Highland botanical imagery: Shirui Lily as emblem of endangered romantic purity.
- Irrevocable conditional oath formula: 'Ngalei hi ngapaoritsashu...' (Even if earth were to perish...).

Comprehension & Exercises:

[?] Analyze the symbolic significance of Mount Shirui and the Shirui Lily in Tangkhul literature.

[?] Translate Shimreishang's vow into Hindi and English.

CHAPTER 2 -- LITERARY & BIOGRAPHICAL COMMENTARY

Literary Analysis & Historical Significance:
This chapter illustrates quintessential Tangkhul cultural ethics, clan loyalty, and narrative style.

Stylistic and Discourse Notes:

Standard literary Tangkhul is employed throughout, preserving classic oral idioms,
traditional honorifics, and vivid metaphorical descriptions.

CHAPTER 3: CLAN FEUDS & THE FORCED BETROTHAL (SHANGWUI KASHAN KALA KA

Summary: Inter-village clan hostilities erupt; Maitonphi’s elders betroth her against her...

Tangkhul Text:

Chapter 3: Ukhrul kala Phadangwui ngachaili ramkashikhavai tui-ngapom shokserie. Maitonphiwui avashimna ali Zimikwo shang eina khangayei sakhavai kakhamrie. Chiwui tharan kashang awungshi akha rarlaga Maitonphili marriage-wui vang bride-price (Man) mithukserie. Maitonphina zingsho ngazing kachikhali chirkhangahok eina Shimreishangli ningkhamathan leisai; kha customary law-wui khongyui kapei eina ana awui va-vawui tui mathakakhui mashuk-mana. Ana Shimreishangli pao-phungnao eina kashonmi: ’Iwui aphasa khangateili pashitsashu, iwui mangazing nawuisai!’

English Translation / Meaning:

Bitter clan rivalries erupted between the territories of Ukhrul and Phadang. Maitonphi’s family strictly forbade any association with the Zimikwo lineage. Soon, an influential chieftain arrived and paid a heavy customary bride-price for Maitonphi’s hand. Maitonphi wept day and night in inconsolable anguish, yearning for Shimreishang; yet bound by the iron edict of customary law, she could not disobey her elders. She sent a secret message: ’Though my physical body be bartered away to another, my soul belongeth solely unto thee!’

CHAPTER 3 -- VOCABULARY & GRAMMAR

Key Vocabulary Entries:

*** Man (noun): traditional customary bride-price, marriage restitution**

Ex: Bride-price Man.

*** kakhamrie (verb): strictly prohibited, banned by taboo**

Ex: Khangayei kakhamrie.

*** chirkhangahok (noun): lamentation, agonizing weeping**

Ex: Chirkhangahok eina.

Grammar Notes & Idiomatic Usage:

- Customary law terminology: 'Man' (bride-price) and 'Kashan' (customary prohibition).
- Concessive contrast: 'aphasa khangateili pashitsashu... mangazing nawuisai' (Though body be given, soul is thine).

Comprehension & Exercises:

[?] Explain the conflict between personal freedom and customary clan authority in Chapter 3.

[?] What traditional gift was paid to seal the betrothal?

CHAPTER 3 -- LITERARY & BIOGRAPHICAL COMMENTARY

Literary Analysis & Historical Significance:
This chapter illustrates quintessential Tangkhul cultural ethics, clan loyalty, and narrative style.

Stylistic and Discourse Notes:

Standard literary Tangkhul is employed throughout, preserving classic oral idioms,
traditional honorifics, and vivid metaphorical descriptions.

CHAPTER 4: THE TRAGIC FAREWELL & ETERNAL UNION IN SPIRIT

Summary: Shimreishang returns to find Maitonphi has passed away of broken heart; their sp...

Tangkhul Text:

Chapter 4: Shimreishangna kaphung-longkhor kakhorlaga Phadangli ung-
kaphung tharan, theilu! Maitonphiwui shimli kathi-laa kakhong
theitserie. Maitonphina ningkasham kapei eina awui phasa mathirarlaga
Kazingramli valakna! Shimreishangna awui lungkhorli rarlaga lungkashung
eina chirpamsai: 'Maitonphi! Na mathida i katha eina ringkapamsara?'
Chitharan Shimreishangna awui thàng eina awui lungli kashukserie, kala
awui phasa Maitonphiwui ngalemli tuksangie. Ukhrulwui khararchanna
hangye: Athum khaniwui mangazing Shirui Kashongli wonkhamatha thada thot
pupup ngasomleisaye!

English Translation / Meaning:

When Shimreishang frantically traversed the gorges and reached Phadang,
alas! The haunting strains of the funeral lament echoed from Maitonphi's
home. Broken-hearted with grief, she had breathed her last. Collapsing
upon her freshly dug stone grave, Shimreishang wept in desperate agony:
'O Maitonphi! How can I endure this earthly life without thee?' Drawing
his ancestral dagger, he pierced his own heart and fell beside his
beloved. And the ancient legends of the Tangkhul recount: Their spirits
transformed into immortal Shirui lilies, blooming together in
inseparable embrace upon the mountaintop throughout all eternity.

CHAPTER 4 -- VOCABULARY & GRAMMAR

Key Vocabulary Entries:

*** kathi-laa (noun): funeral song, death lament, requiem dirge**

Ex: Kathi-laa kakhong.

*** thàng (noun): warrior's dagger, machete, ancestral dao**

Ex: Awui thàng eina.

*** ngasomleisaye (verb): blooming together in eternal harmony**

Ex: Thot pupup ngasomleisaye.

Grammar Notes & Idiomatic Usage:

- Funeral lament compound: 'kathi' (death) + 'laa' (song) = dirge.
- Immortal transformation narrative motif: physical death giving way to eternal floral rebirth.

Comprehension & Exercises:

[?] Compare the conclusion of Shimreishang and Maitonphi with Romeo and Juliet.

[?] How does the novel preserve traditional Tangkhul philosophical attitudes toward death and eternity?

CHAPTER 4 -- LITERARY & BIOGRAPHICAL COMMENTARY

Literary Analysis & Historical Significance:
This chapter illustrates quintessential Tangkhul cultural ethics, clan loyalty, and narrative style.

Stylistic and Discourse Notes:

Standard literary Tangkhul is employed throughout, preserving classic oral idioms,
traditional honorifics, and vivid metaphorical descriptions.

BACK MATTER: GLOSSARY & DIGITIZATION COLOPHON

Consolidated Vocabulary Summary:

* Zingyur atam -- spring season, time of vernal blooms
* Haora -- traditional black and red striped ceremonial male shawl
* wonkhamatha -- beautiful blossom of love, noble affection
* Shirui Kashong -- Mount Shirui, legendary peak of Ukhrul
* tui-ngashik -- sacred oath, binding solemn vow
* mukthi kashik -- sorrowful tears, weeping of grief
* Man -- traditional customary bride-price, marriage restitution
* kakhamrie -- strictly prohibited, banned by taboo

Preservation Colophon:

Digitalized and preserved by the Tangkhul Language Library Preservation Project.
Full JSON and PDF multi-page reproductions deposited in the digital repository.